MODULE 7: Clickbait

Objective
To help participants understand:
- What clickbait is.
- How attention-grabbing headlines and language entice people to click.
- How clickbait accelerates the spread of false information and confusion.
- How to recognise and avoid clickbait as informed citizens.

7.1 What Is Clickbait?
Clickbait refers to headlines, thumbnails, or text designed to provoke curiosity, fear, anger, or other emotions to attract clicks. However, the content often:
- Does not fully match the headline.
- Exaggerates the facts.
- Presents misleading information.

In simple terms:
The primary purpose of clickbait is to attract clicks rather than inform.

7.2 Why Is Clickbait Created?
Common motivations include:
- Increasing views and reach.
- Generating more advertising revenue.
- Gaining popularity on social media.
- Going viral quickly.

On digital platforms where likes, shares, and views are highly valued, clickbait is used as an effective but risky strategy.

7.3 Common Clickbait Techniques
Clickbait commonly uses the following techniques:

1. Incomplete or Mysterious Headlines
- “This video will leave you amazed.”
- “You won’t believe the ending.”

2. Exaggerated Claims
- “The biggest event in history.”
- “This news will change everything.”

3. Fear or Panic
- “Ignoring this could cost you dearly.”
- “Everyone is making this mistake.”

4. Emotionally Charged Language
- Words that evoke anger, distress, sympathy, or excitement.

5. Misleading Thumbnails
- Images or scenes that do not match the headline.

7.4 The Relationship Between Clickbait and Information Disorder
Clickbait does not always contain false information, but it can:
- Help spread misinformation.
- Bring disinformation to a wider audience.

7.5 Why People Fall for Clickbait

Common psychological factors and habits include:

- Curiosity.
- Fear of missing out (FOMO).
- Emotionally charged topics.
- Rapid scrolling.
- Making judgements based on headlines alone.

Clickbait thrives on the tendency to make quick decisions online.

7.6 Clickbait in the Bangladesh Context

Clickbait is particularly effective in Bangladesh because of:

- Frequent reliance on social media as a primary information source.
- Rapid scrolling on mobile phones.
- A tendency to trust headlines before verifying them.
- Strong emotions surrounding elections, social issues, and civic matters.

As a result, clickbait can create confusion and misconceptions in society.

7.7 Warning Signs of Clickbait

Be alert to the following signs:

- Headlines that convey emotion but little factual information.
- Phrases such as “You won’t believe this.”
- A mismatch between the headline and the content.
- A lack of reliable sources.
- Exaggerated or dramatic language.

A headline that withholds essential information may warrant closer scrutiny.

7.8 When You Encounter Clickbait

Do:

- Read or watch the full content.
- Verify the source.
- Check the information against other reliable sources.
- Avoid sharing when in doubt.

Don’t:

- Share based on headlines alone.
- Comment impulsively.
- Accept misleading thumbnails as factual.
- Make decisions without verifying the information.

7.9 Clickbait and Responsible Citizenship

As responsible citizens, we can:

- Raise awareness rather than reward clickbait with engagement.
- Break the chain of misinformation by refusing to share unverified content.

Choosing not to click can also be a responsible decision.